✦ METALS MADE SIMPLE SERIES ✦

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7 Warning Signs Your Metals Dealer Is Ripping You Off

What to watch for before you hand over a single dollar — from someone who has seen it all over 30 years in the metals market

FEDERAL REGULATORS HAVE DOCUMENTED HUNDREDS OF MILLIONS IN LOSSES FROM THESE TACTICS. KNOW THEM BEFORE YOU BUY.

> *Most precious metals dealers are honest, hardworking professionals. But the industry has more than its fair share of those who put their own profits ahead of your best interest. Here is what I have seen over 30 years — and what to watch for.*

1 MARKUPS THAT SEEM TOO HIGH

Standard dealer markups on bullion typically run **1% to 8% above the current spot price.** Real cases documented by federal regulators have shown markups of 50% or more sold to buyers who had no idea what a fair price looked like. Knowing the spot price before you call any dealer is one of the most protective things you can do.

✓ Look up the current spot price independently before speaking with any dealer. It takes 30 seconds and gives you an immediate frame of reference.

2 BAIT AND SWITCH PRICING

A dealer advertises an attractive low price, then steers you toward different — and more profitable — products once you engage. Common lines include **"that item is sold out"** or **"this one is actually a much better value for you."** The replacement product almost always earns them significantly more margin.

✓ If the advertised product is unavailable, it is generally worth looking elsewhere rather than accepting a substitution you were not planning to make.

3 HIGH-PRESSURE URGENCY

Phrases like **"prices are going up tomorrow,"** "limited supply — act now," or "this offer expires today" are well-documented pressure tactics in this industry. In my experience, dealers who respect their customers give them time to think, compare, and ask questions before making a decision.

✓ There is rarely a genuine emergency in metals buying. Taking a day or two to compare options and think it through is almost always the right call.

4 HEAVY PUSH TOWARD NUMISMATIC COINS

Numismatic and semi-numismatic coins can be legitimate investments — but they generally require **specialized knowledge that most buyers do not have.** Dealers earn significantly more on these than on standard bullion. Without that expertise, you may pay a meaningful premium and find resale more complicated than with standard government-minted coins.

✓ Unless you have specific experience with collectible coins, standard government-minted bullion is generally easier to buy, price, and sell.

5 VAGUE OR UNCLEAR ADDITIONAL COSTS

Before you commit to a purchase, it is worth asking specifically about any costs beyond the metal itself — **shipping, insurance, handling, or storage fees** if applicable. Federal regulators have documented cases where customers were charged ongoing fees for services that were misrepresented or did not exist as described.

✓ Simply asking "are there any additional costs beyond the price of the metal itself?" is a reasonable question that any straightforward dealer should answer clearly.

6 AGGRESSIVE IRA OR 401(K) ROLLOVER PRESSURE

Federal regulators have specifically flagged this tactic. Dealers who aggressively encourage moving retirement savings into metals — especially with urgency or fear-based language — warrant extra caution. Federal regulators have documented cases where customers were charged substantial fees on retirement account rollovers that were not clearly disclosed upfront. Retirement funds deserve an especially high level of scrutiny.

✓ If a metals dealer is offering guidance on your IRA or retirement plan, it is worth asking whether they are a licensed, registered investment advisor.

7 UNWILLING TO TELL YOU THE SPOT PRICE OR WHAT YOU ARE PAYING ABOVE IT

One of the simplest questions you can ask any metals dealer is: **"What is today's spot price, and what am I paying above it?"** In my experience, dealers who are confident in their pricing answer that question directly and without hesitation. Those who become evasive or redirect the conversation when you ask — that is worth paying attention to. You are entitled to understand what you are paying and why.

✓ This one question — asked before every purchase — can tell you a great deal about the dealer you are working with.

A FEW THINGS WORTH DOING BEFORE YOU BUY

- Look up the current spot price independently before calling any dealer
- Ask what you are paying above spot — a good dealer answers this directly
- Ask about any costs beyond the metal itself before committing
- Search the dealer's name online to see what others have experienced
- Take the time you need — urgency is rarely your friend in this market
- Comparing a few dealers on price before buying is always worth the effort

THE DEALER I USE AND TRUST PERSONALLY

At-Cost Pricing — No Games, No Pressure, No Hidden Fees

After 30 years of buying metals from dealers all over the country, I found one that does things differently. They sell at **actual dealer cost** — not inflated retail markup. Members consistently save **7–10%** compared to virtually everywhere else. Price them against any dealer you are currently considering. The difference tends to speak for itself.

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No obligation. No sales pressure. Just compare their pricing to anyone else.

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